

credible to employees.

The employees at IMVU would brandish one-page reports to demonstrate what they had learned to settle arguments, but the process often wasn't so smooth. Most of the time, when a manager, developer, or team was confronted with results that would kill a pet project, the loser of the argument would challenge the veracity of the data.

Such challenges are more common than most managers would admit, and unfortunately, most data reporting systems are not designed to answer them successfully. Sometimes this is the result of a well-intentioned but misplaced desire to protect the privacy of customers. More often, the lack of such supporting documentation is simply a matter of neglect. Most data reporting systems are not built by product development teams, whose job is to prioritize and build product features. They are built by business managers and analysts. Managers who must use these systems can only check to see if the reports are mutually consistent. They all too often lack a way to test if the data is consistent with reality.

The solution? First, remember that "Metrics are people, too." We need to be able to test the data by hand, in the messy real world, by talking to customers. This is the only way to be able to check if the reports contain true facts. Managers need the ability to spot check the data with real customers. It also has a second benefit: systems that provide this level of auditability give managers and entrepreneurs the opportunity to gain insights into why customers are behaving the way the data indicate.

Second, those building reports must make sure the mechanisms that generate the reports are not too complex. Whenever possible, reports should be drawn directly from the master data, rather than from an intermediate system, which reduces opportunities for error. I have noticed that every time a team has one of its judgments or assumptions overturned as a result of a technical problem with the data, its confidence, morale, and discipline are undermined.